Baby

By Conrad E. Davidson

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR 1:*** *Coach, Timekeeper, Mommy, Daddy*
ACTOR 2: *Baby*

Baby and Coach are discovered onstage. Baby, dressed in a graduation cap and gown, listens attentively.

COACH: **(Pg 7)** Trick #237 is: suck your thumb, whichever one seems most comfortable. Try it now. First, your right, then your left.

BABY: And if they take it out?

COACH: Be persistent. Pop it right back in. Don't give up.

BABY: I like this.

COACH: Which brings us to the pacifier, the common device parents use to break the habit of their thumb-sucking children. P-A-C-I-F-I-E-R. And when you finally get attached to it, they take it away as quickly, without warning, as they gave it to you. *(Timekeeper enters and hands note to Coach)*

TIMEKEEPER: Two minutes for baby. *(exits)*

BABY: Who's Baby?

COACH: You are since we received advance notice that's what your parents will name you.

BABY: They're going to call me Baby all the time?

COACH: Maybe. As parents, it's their prerogative.

BABY: **(Pg 8-9)** I'm not going.

COACH: Once these things are set in motion, there is no turning back. That's the way of the world.

TIMEKEEPER: One minute for . . . sorry, still no name. One minute for Baby. *(exits)*

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BABY: Dumb. Dumb. Coach, you haven't given me enough advance preparation.

COACH: I've drilled you, lectured you, and demonstrated all the trick of the trade. I can't squeeze nine months of instruction into mere seconds.

BABY: Oh, I don't want to go, I'll never last. They haven't even given me an identity. *(Baby urges Coach on in nonverbal desperation)*

INTRODUCTION

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COACH: **(Pg 9-10)** Squirm and kick when they change your diapers. After the diaper change, wait half a minute and mess again. When they give you a bath, throw water out of the tub. Swallow marbles. Unscrew the nipple off your bottles, dump the milk on the carpet. Throw food on the floor. Rub food in your hair. Pout. Use cry technique #5 – the ear pierce. Have a fit at least once a day.

TIMEKEEPER: Ten seconds.

COACH: After a hard sneeze, rub it in your face with your hands. Vomit whenever it's convenient.

BABY: I'll never remember all those things!

TIMEKEEPER: Four. Three. Two. One. Time. **(Pg 11)** It's time *(exits)*

BABY: If they want me, they'll have to come and . . . *(Baby is pulled by an unseen force off stage)* Wait a minute. Stop pulling. I didn't ask for this. What about the democratic right of choice? Choice! Choice!

********Scene Change**********

MOMMY: **(Pg 12)** Feels so good to have cutesy Baby at home, doesn't it, Daddy? One little grin for Mommy-pooh.

DADDY: One little smile, Baby-kins.

BABY: Mommy-pooh? Baby-kins? You are dumb dumb dumb.

DADDY: **(Pg 14)** Watch me teach Baby another word. Baby knows sixty words already. Pretty good for only four months old.

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BABY: Four months?

DADDY: **(Pg 15)** Synorthographic.

BABY: Someone make him stop this stupidity.

DADDY: *(Bending close to Baby as baby holds his breath. Daddy's breath smells*!) Synor ...

BABY: Can't breathe.

DADDY: tho . . .

BABY: Suffocating.

DADDY: graphic . . . ic

BABBY: I'm choking. I'm going to pass out. *(Baby yells)*

DADDY: Very good, Baby. Means spelled alike.

BABY: I wasn't close at all, dummy. *(sucking in a big breath)* Ahhhhh. Fresh air.

MOMMY: **(Pg 16)** You're six months old now, Baby. Time to learn to crawl. *(Mommy positions baby on the floor)* First one hand, then the other. Push Baby's butt, hubby dear. *(Baby falls forward on his face and yells)*

BABY: First the words, now this butt business. These people aren't normal. **(Pg 17)** *(Daddy picks up Baby and tosses him in the air)* Put me down, you loonies. I'm getting sick. Do babies ever outlive this stupidity?

DADDY: **(Pg 21)** *(puts baby on the floor and shoves butt)* Biodynamic. . . Coprolalia . . . Peniapolis . . . Salmagundi

BABY: **(Pg 22)** Stop pushing. Cut it with the words. You're going to make me cry. You weirdos don't know when to quit. **(Pg 23)** STOOOOOOPP! *(Daddy freezes)* Where's that coach?

COACH: *(Stepping forward)* Been here all along. Speak.

BABY: Don't interrupt, don't pinch my cheeks, don't breathe in my face, don't shove my butt. Just sit and listen. If I have to endure any more of that insanity, I'll go nuts. I don't want to know what the next what-should-we-do-that's-weird-to-Baby business will be. The thought makes me want to scream. *(Baby screams)*

COACH: Hold it. Hold it. Don't let it be a one-sided battle. Fight back. *(Baby looks confused)* **(Pg 24-25)** You've forgotten your pre-baby training. You need on-the-job training. They

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won't be able to see or hear me, so don't worry about that. *(Coach snaps fingers. Baby screams in desperation and poops his diaper. Mommy and Daddy enter)*

MOMMY: Ohhhhh. Baby messed again. Change Baby, hubby dear.

DADDY: Certainly, Mommy. While I do, I'll teach Baby another word. Nyctalopia. The condition of seeing poorly at night or in partial darkness.

BABY: *(to Coach)* What do I do? I can't stand this word business.

COACH: Wait until he gets your diaper off, then stick your hands in it. *(Baby does)*

DADDY: Help, honey, Baby , just stuck . . . ick.

COACH: That's the stuff, kid. When they put the clean diaper on, pretend they poked you. *(BABY screams)*

DADDY: Baby was squirming. Baby never squirms. *(leans in to settle Baby down)* A word. Baby always likes new words . . . Chromatography. Anomahitic. Quondom.

BABY: **(Pg 26)** He's going to breathe in my face. *(to Coach)* What'll I do?

COACH: **(Pg 28)** Bite him. *(Baby bites)*

BABY: **(Pg 26)** This isn't bad.

COACH: You've got them running, kid.

DADDY: **(Pg 25)** Baby is one year old today.

MOMMY: **(Pg 29-30)** Hurry, hubby. Baby's birthday party guests are here!

BABY: *(to Coach)* What's a party?

COACH: The best time for baby tricks. *(Daddy picks up baby and tosses him in the air)*

BABY: I really hate this.

COACH: Let him have it! *(Baby throws up)* Serves him right!

MOMMY: Look, Baby, a present . . . MARBLES! *(Baby takes marbles, looks at them, then pops them into mouth. Mommy panics)* Spit them out, Baby. Call the doctor, hubby. *(Mommy attempts to get Baby to open mouth. Coach snaps fingers and all freeze)*

COACH: You don't need me any more, kid. Look how you've been handling the situation. That was a real nice touch – faking like you swallowed the marbles.

BABY: That was good, wasn't it? Thought of it myself.

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COACH: It's your first birthday and I've got to go. Other babies to instruct, you know. Keep your chin up, kid. You'll survive. Give it to them with both barrels. *(Coach exits) (as a disembodied voice while baby pantomimes the actions)* **(Pg 9-10)** Squirm and kick when they change your diapers. Swallow marbles. Unscrew the nipple off your bottles, dump the milk on the carpet. Throw food on the floor. Rub food in your hair. Have a fit at least once a day.

MOMMY: Will we ever survive babyhood?

BABY: *(Turns to grin slowly at the audience)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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